

Bulk Text Replacement for Word

User Manual - search and replace across many Word documents at once

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Getting started

Opening the application

- **From File Explorer:** Right-click a Word document -> "Open with" -> select the Python script, or use the context menu entry.
- **From the command line:** `python word_text_replacer_single_with_add.py [optional_file_path]`.
- **Direct launch:** Double-click the Python script.

Interface overview

The window is laid out top to bottom, in the order you normally work:

- **Selected files:** Add, remove and manage Word documents. Includes "Add folder" for recursive folder scans and the  Hyperlink check.
- **Search for:** The text to find.  nbsp check reports non-breaking spaces in your search and replace text.
- **Replace with:** The text to insert.
- **Options:** Create backups, case sensitivity, regex, whole word match.
- **Action buttons:** Preview, Standard Replace, Advanced Replace, ↔ Restore backups.
- **Live match counter:** Counts matches across all selected files as you type, before you run anything.

Note: The live counter and Standard Preview look at main content only (paragraphs and tables). They do not scan text boxes, headers, footers, footnotes or form fields. "Live: No matches found" therefore does not mean that Advanced Replace will find nothing either.

File management

Adding files

- **Add more files:** Pick one or more documents (.docx, .doc, .docm). Shortcut: Ctrl+O.
- **Add folder:** Pick a folder and every Word document inside it is added, including all sub-folders. Word lock files (~\$...) are skipped automatically, and you get a confirmation showing how many documents were found.

Files added through "Add folder" are listed with their path relative to the folder you picked, so documents that share the same file name in different language folders stay distinguishable.

Managing the list

- **Remove selected:** Select one or more entries and click the button or press Delete.
- **Clear all:** Empties the whole list.
- **Duplicate protection:** Duplicates are filtered out automatically, so adding the same folder twice does not create double entries.
- **File count:** Shown at the bottom right of the file section and in the window title.

Text input features

Search and Replace boxes

- **Multi-line:** Both boxes accept multiple lines.
- **Navigation:** Tab moves between the boxes; Ctrl+1 and Ctrl+2 jump straight to them.
- **Undo / Redo:** Ctrl+Z and Ctrl+Y inside each box.
- **Tab character:** Ctrl+Tab inserts a real tab character instead of moving focus.

Paste clipboard

Each box has a  Paste clipboard button that replaces the box content with whatever is on the clipboard - handy when copying terms out of another application.

Non-breaking spaces

Non-breaking spaces prevent a line break between two words and are common in professional documents. Because you cannot see them, the tool gives you an explicit way to handle them:

1. **Shortcut:** Press Shift+Space in either box.
2. **Manual:** Type `_nbsp_` anywhere in your text.

Every `_nbsp_` placeholder is converted to a real non-breaking space before searching and replacing.  nbsp check shows how many non-breaking spaces your search and replace text currently contain.

Note: Invisible formatting characters such as soft hyphens and zero-width spaces are stripped before matching, so a word that Word has silently hyphenated is still found.

Replacement methods

There are two engines. They differ in how much of the document they reach and how fast they are.

Standard Replace (fast)

Uses python-docx and never starts Microsoft Word. Typically a few seconds for dozens of files.

Area	Covered
Paragraphs and body text	Yes
Tables, including nested tables	Yes
Headers and footers	No
Text boxes and shapes	No
Footnotes and endnotes	No
Form fields	No
Hyperlink display text	Yes, but the link itself is lost

- **Regex:** Regex is supported here, and only here.
- **Hyperlinks:** Changing the display text of a hyperlink updates the text but removes the link. If you are not touching hyperlink text, Standard Replace is perfectly safe.

Advanced Replace (complete)

Drives Microsoft Word through COM automation. Slower, because every document is opened in Word, but it reaches everything.

Area	Covered
Paragraphs and body text	Yes
Tables, including nested tables	Yes
Headers and footers	Yes
Text boxes and shapes	Yes
Footnotes and endnotes	Yes
Form fields	Yes
Hyperlink display text	Yes, and the link is preserved

- **Regex:** Not supported - Word's own search engine is used, which does not understand Python regex syntax.
- **Your open Word:** Advanced Replace starts its own, separate Word process. A Word session you already have open is left alone: it is not hidden, not disturbed and not closed.

Note: A document that is currently open in Word cannot be saved by the tool, because Word holds a lock on the file. Such a file is reported as an error in the results window rather than being silently skipped.

Choosing between them

Situation	Recommended
Plain text in paragraphs and tables	Standard Replace
Large batches where speed matters	Standard Replace
Search pattern uses regex	Standard Replace
Text in headers, footers or text boxes	Advanced Replace
Hyperlink display text is being changed	Advanced Replace
Footnotes, endnotes or form fields	Advanced Replace
Not sure what the document contains	Advanced Preview first

Timestamps, backups and restoring

Only changed files are written

The tool reads every file you selected, but it only writes the ones where something actually changed. A document without a single match is never saved, so its modification date stays exactly as it was. After a run you can sort a folder by "Date modified" and see precisely which documents the tool touched.

This applies to both Standard Replace and Advanced Replace. The results window reports it explicitly as "Files modified (saved)".

Backup files

- **How to enable:** Tick "Create backup files (.backup)" before running a replacement.
- **Naming:** forza_inter.docx becomes forza_inter.docx.backup, right next to the original.
- **Scope:** Only files that are actually modified get a backup. Untouched documents do not clutter your folders.
- **Protection:** An existing .backup file is never overwritten. Your first backup remains the original state of the document, no matter how many times you run the tool afterwards.

Restoring from a backup

The ⇐ Restore backups button rolls files back to their backed-up state. It works on the file list at the top of the window - the same selection you use for replacing:

1. Make sure the documents you want to roll back are in the file list. "Add folder" is the quickest way to get a whole tree back.
2. Close the documents in Microsoft Word.
3. Click ⇐ Restore backups.
4. For every listed file that has a matching .backup next to it, the backup is copied back over the original. Files without a backup are skipped and counted separately.
5. Confirm the summary, then choose whether the .backup files should be deleted after a successful restore.

A results window shows how many files were restored, how many had no backup, and any errors.

Note: You do not have to highlight anything in the list. The restore always considers every file in the list; highlighting is only used by the "Remove selected" button.

Preview options

Pressing Preview (or F5) asks which of the two previews you want. Nothing is ever written during a preview.

Standard Preview (fast)

- **Coverage:** Main content only - paragraphs and tables.
- **Speed:** Very fast; no Word involved.
- **Detail:** Shows the match count per file plus up to five context snippets per file, with the match highlighted in square brackets inside its surrounding sentence.

Advanced Preview (complete)

- **Coverage:** Every area Advanced Replace reaches, broken down per area.
- **Speed:** Slower; opens each document in Word.
- **Detail:** Reports matches separately for text boxes, headers, footers, footnotes, endnotes, form fields, hyperlinks and main content.

Results windows

Every preview, replacement, hyperlink check and restore ends in a results window. They all share the same features.

- **Resizable and maximizable:** The window can be resized and maximized, which helps when a run covers dozens of files.
- **Show only affected files:** Tick this box to hide every file that had no matches. Files that failed with an error are never hidden, whatever the filter says.
-  **Export results:** Saves the results as a .txt file, exactly as currently displayed. If the filter is ticked, the exported file contains only the affected documents; if it is not, the export contains the full list.
- **Stable numbering:** File numbering stays stable when you filter, so "FILE 27" refers to the same document whether the filter is on or off.

Hyperlink management

Hyperlink check

The  Hyperlink check button scans the selected files and reports how many hyperlinks each one contains, with sample display texts and targets. Use it when you are unsure whether Standard Replace is safe for a batch.

Which method is safe

Scenario	Standard Replace	Advanced Replace
No hyperlinks in the document	Safe and fast	Safe, slower
Hyperlinks present, not being modified	Safe and fast	Safe
Hyperlink display text is being modified	Breaks the links	Preserves the links

Options and settings

Create backup files (.backup)

See "Timestamps, backups and restoring". Off by default.

Case sensitive search

- **Unchecked (default):** Case-insensitive. "Hello" also matches "hello" and "HELLO".
- **Checked:** "Hello" matches only "Hello". Works with both replacement methods.

Regex (Standard Replace only)

- **Unchecked (default):** The search text is treated as plain text.
- **Checked:** The search text is a Python regular expression, for example `\d+` or `(foo|bar)`. Invalid patterns are reported before anything runs.

Note: Regex works with Standard Preview and Standard Replace only. Advanced Preview and Advanced Replace use Word's native search engine and will ask you to untick the box.

Whole word match

- **Unchecked (default):** "use" also matches inside "reuse" and "useful".
- **Checked:** "use" matches the standalone word only. Works with both replacement methods.

Keyboard shortcuts

Actions

Shortcut	Action
F5	Preview (asks for Standard or Advanced)
Ctrl+Enter	Standard Replace
Ctrl+Shift+Enter	Standard Replace, then close the application
Shift+Enter	Advanced Replace
Ctrl+O	Add more files
Escape or Ctrl+Q	Close the application

Navigation

Shortcut	Action
Ctrl+1	Focus the Search box
Ctrl+2	Focus the Replace box
Tab	Switch between the two boxes

Text editing

Shortcut	Action
Ctrl+Tab	Insert a tab character
Ctrl+Z	Undo
Ctrl+Y	Redo
Shift+Space	Insert a non-breaking space placeholder (_nbsp_)

File list (when the list has focus)

Shortcut	Action
Delete	Remove the selected files from the list

Technical requirements

- **Operating system:** Windows.
- **Python:** Python 3.x including tkinter.
- **Required library:** python-docx, required for Standard Replace, previews and the live counter.
- **Optional:** Microsoft Word plus pywin32, required for Advanced Preview and Advanced Replace only. Without them the Standard features still work.

Troubleshooting

Common messages

- **"Document is locked" / "Permission denied"**: The document is open in Microsoft Word. Close it and run again.
- **"Regex Not Supported"**: Untick the Regex box, or use Standard Replace instead.
- **"Advanced replace requires the pywin32 package"**: Install it with: `pip install pywin32`.

Unexpected results

- **Nothing found, but you can see the text**: The live counter and Standard Preview only scan paragraphs and tables. Run an Advanced Preview to check headers, footers, text boxes, footnotes and form fields.
- **Fewer files changed than expected**: That is intended. Files without a match are never written, so their modification date is preserved. Check "Files modified (saved)" in the results window.
- **No new backup was created**: An existing .backup is never overwritten, so the backup still holds the state from the first run - which is usually what you want for a rollback.

Recovering from a bad run

1. If backups were enabled, put the affected files in the list and use ⇄ Restore backups.
2. If a run failed part way through, the documents processed before the failure are still saved correctly; the results window lists exactly which file failed and why.
3. Use Preview before a large batch. It costs seconds and shows the exact matches beforehand.

Finally

All good things come to an end, and so does this manual. Before we finish, one more thing: the tool is free and I am happy to share it with whoever wants to use it. If you like it, you can buy me a coffee. And do connect with me!